ENTERTAINMENT

His Father's Son

In Netflix's *Friday Night Plan*, BABIL KHAN tries to showcase a style distinct from his father, Irrfan



HARDIK CHHABRA

There's an infectious energy to Babil Khan, 25. It's in sharp contrast to his father, the late Irrfan, whose eyes alone could register and radiate his presence. Irrfan passed away in April 2020, before he could see his eldest follow in his footsteps and become an actor (Netflix's *Qala*, 2022). His father's thespian legacy is both a boost and occasionally a bane for the young Babil whose second feature, *Friday Night Plan*, released on Netflix on September 1. "My biggest challenge is to enter an audition room and detach myself from the image of Baba," he says. "I am sensitive to the environment around so I know when somebody is disappointed because I am not acting like him." It's a mammoth expectation, especially for someone just starting out.

Yet Babil is conscious that he has a leg-up compared to other aspirants courtesy his father's legacy. It gets him a foot in the door, but, thereafter, it is a "completely different battle". Says Babil, "I have my own style and identity and Baba would be disappointed if I tried to be him." Much like his father, whose talent would take time to be recognised, Babil is excitedly embarking on his own journey. He has auditioned for parts and admits to not cracking a few, but he isn't losing heart. Babil may not have got the acting lessons he sought from his father, but his childhood in many ways prepared him for the job. He was raised in an atmosphere soaked in art. "It's like you are a vessel and you are surrendering to it. You have to absorb and experience," he says. He grew up on the spiritual, philosophical cinema of Tarkovsky; he was nine when Irrfan made him see Stanley Kubrick's *Full Metal Jacket* and recalls a home where in one room there was Osho's discourse and in another Jim Morrison's music playing. Irrfan would make him perform in front of his friends and was the first to tell him he was an actor.

Friday Night Plan sees Babil play Sid, a character he describes as "the complete opposite of me". The young adult dramedy centres on a relationship between two brothers, which hits a flashpoint one Friday when they let loose in their mother's absence. Babil, too, has a younger brother, Ayan, who much like his on-screen brother, he says, is "more mature". Post *Friday Night Plan*, Babil will be seen in a web series, *The Railway Men*, set against the backdrop of the Bhopal gas tragedy. There's also an independent feature and another film in the works. A theatrical release still eludes him. Is it something that he mulls over? "I do not believe in strategy. You should be dependent on your instinct as an artist," he says. "There is turmoil in me. What I am seeking is to be a great actor. I want to know I have successfully explored a character in all possible ways." Words his father would surely be proud of. ■

MUCH LIKE HIS FATHER IRRFAN, WHOSE TALENT TOOK TIME TO BE RECOGNISED, BABIL IS EXCITEDLY EMBARKING ON HIS OWN JOURNEY

Suhani Singh